

Art and decoration

The Celts were a warlike people, but they were gifted craftworkers and artists too. Celtic metalworkers excelled at decorated weaponry, jewellery, vessels, and mirrors. After the conversion to Christianity, Celtic monks in the British Isles made illustrated holy books of awesome detail. The Lindisfarne Gospels (c.700) feature 45 different colours – all made from finely ground minerals or vegetable dyes.

Battersea shield

Many of the most beautiful bronze Celtic shields were too thin for use in battle, and were purely ornamental. The Battersea shield was probably used only for military parades. It was found in the River Thames, London, in 1857.



Battersea shield

Torc

According to the ancient Greek writer, Strabo, Celts loved to dress in colourful clothes and wear jewellery in gold, silver, or electrum (an alloy of gold and silver): "They wear torcs around their necks, and bracelets on their arms and wrists," he wrote. Many gold, bronze, and silver torcs have been found in Celtic graves.



Electrum torc

Tara brooch

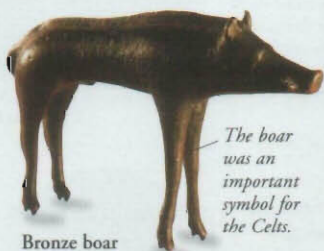
Brooches, such as the Tara, date from the 8th century – the early Christian era in Celtic Ireland. Only 9 cms (3.5 inches) in diameter, the Tara brooch is a magnificently detailed piece of jewellery, featuring filigree, gilt chip-carvings, enamelled glass, amber, and gold wire.



Tara brooch

Sculpture

Animals and birds often figured in Celtic art and decoration, and certain animals were sacred, such as pigs or boars, which often appear in Celtic legend. The legendary King Arthur himself was known as "the Boar of Cornwall".



Bronze boar

Metalworking

As well as sophisticated iron weaponry and farming tools, skilled Celtic metalworkers produced high-status goods for chieftains, and elaborately decorated vessels for trade throughout Europe. In Gaul (modern France) the smiths even had their own god – a smith-god known as Súcéllos.

Sword and shield
Swirling abstract pattern



Chieftain's bronze couch, Germany

Wagon pulled by horses

Wheel

Female figure

Christianity

During the Roman occupation, Christianity came to Britain – but failed to take deep root. However one convert, St Patrick, went on to convert pagan Celtic Ireland in the 5th century. After this, the Celts adopted the religion with gusto and Ireland became a Christian stronghold for the next three centuries.



Celtic cross

Monks

Celtic Christianity was famous for the harshness of the monks' lives, and the enthusiasm of their devotions. From c.500, monasteries ranged from simple cells for single monks to communities the size of towns.



Early Christian church, Ireland

Missionaries

After Irish Christians set up monasteries in Britain, France, and northern Italy, they started to convert the native peoples. The monks loved learning and helped to keep culture alive in Europe, during the chaos that followed the decline of the Roman Empire. Irish monks operating from the island of Iona, off western Scotland, produced the beautiful *Book of Kells*, c.800, with its extraordinary illuminated (decorated) lettering.

Monogram page, Gospel of St Matthew, *Book of Kells*

XRI is short for "Christ".

Greek letter X

Greek R



Myths

The pagan Celts had a rich oral tradition. Their stories included myths about mighty gods, such as the Welsh Bran the Blessed, and the Irish Dagda (Father of All); legends about fearless warrior-heroes, such as Cúchulainn and King Arthur; and tales of the "shape-changers" – magical creatures from the Underworld. Since the Celts had no written language, monks later wrote down the stories for future generations.



Merlin

The first written legends of the Welsh wizard, Merlin, said that he was a Celtic boy whose father was the devil. At an early age, he found he could foretell the future. In later stories, he appeared as the wizard and mentor of King Arthur of England.

Engraving of the wizard Merlin

Languages

Two types of Celtic language continue to be spoken and written today: Brythonic (Breton, Welsh, Cornish) and Gaelic (Irish, Scots Gaelic, Manx). They may all be traced back to a common ancient Indo-European language.



Modern Irish

"Hill"

"Beach"

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